

DRY HEAT

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The place reeked of stale coffee, dust baked onto warm plastic and metal, wood polish yellowed with age, paper going brittle in the desert air, and the metallic tang of blood congealing on Spanish tile. The silence of the small crowd huddled behind me made the smell hit harder, like walking into a wall of bad news.

Silence beat the hell out of the circus act from an hour ago. Give credit where it's due – the world-class scientists of this venerable institution knew how to panic with dignity. Couldn't say the same for the administrator who'd stumbled onto this mess. When I rolled up, she was still doing her impression of a fire alarm with legs. Now she stood with the others, faces running the spectrum from mint green to lime, but keeping their breakfast where it belonged.

Dr. Ray Pritchett and his crime scene team had finally finished their dance with death.

"Anything jump out at you?" I asked, rolling a Lucky Strike in my fingers – no lighting up in the non-smoking place. The desert air wafting in from the open door was dry enough to mummify a pharaoh.

"Nothing screaming for attention yet, Martinez. Scene's yours." Pritchett was a man who hoarded words like they cost him by the letter. I turned to face the assembled brain trust of the Santa Fe Laboratory.

"Ladies and gentlemen, I need you to return to your offices but don't leave the premises. I'll be making the rounds for some friendly conversation with each of you."

As I bent to slip on protective shoe covers, my gaze locked with two emerald orbs the size of poker chips. An enormous ginger tom cat, built like a small tiger, watched me with the

composure of a sphinx from his post under a mahogany table. The cat had seen something over the weekend, that much was certain. Too bad he wasn't talking – yet.

I pulled on two pairs of latex gloves, the snap echoing off adobe walls like a gunshot, and stepped into what used to be someone's world.

Last Friday, this office probably looked like standard academic issue: leather-bound volumes that cost more than my car, research papers, computer equipment humming with the sound of discovery, framed photographs documenting a life—in retrospect—lived dangerously, filing cabinets standing at attention. This Monday morning told a different story. Drawers hung open like slack jaws, contents rifled through with the efficiency of someone looking for buried treasure. Otherwise, the chaos was contained. Professional.

Well, professional except for the pool of blood painting the tile floor in shades of crimson that belonged in a Hitchcock film.

The stain was impressive but not biblical – maybe three pints, not the full gallon a human body carried around like a crimson savings account. Working hypothesis: it belonged to the office's tenant, Dr. Abraham Helsing. The irony of the name wasn't lost on me. In this business, irony was about as common as hangovers.

The blood pool's edge spawned a clean drag mark with two parallel tracks, like someone had used a sled. Hard to picture the choreography that would create such a neat border with those tracks leading away unless you had multiple dancers in this particular ballet. If someone had collapsed in that pool, the disturbance would've looked like a Jackson Pollock painting. The tracks stopped dead after about six feet, neat as you please. If there'd been a body – and that was still an if in my book – someone had wrapped it tighter than a Christmas present at that point.

I crossed to examine the wall gallery. Several photographs showed people clinging to existence in outdoor settings: hanging off cliff faces like human icicles, waving from glaciers that could kill you just by looking at them wrong, racing down steep wooded trails that would challenge a mountain goat, grinning from crevasses that went deeper than most people's nightmares. The common denominator was a friendly-looking character who seemed familiar in that generic way scientists had around here. I'd privately dubbed the look "academic ascetic chic" – shaved heads polished to a shine, not an ounce of spare flesh, skin tanned to leather by high-altitude UV exposure. Extreme athletes who happened to have advanced degrees.

This particular specimen looked like he could run to Colorado and back before lunch, then come up with a workable unified field theory for dessert.

I stepped outside, peeled off the gloves with a snap that sounded like breaking joints, and tossed the whole package to one of Pritchett's people. They were expanding their search perimeter now, hunting for clues.

The building had history written in its bones. Sometime back when the world was younger and money grew on trees, this place was a private villa belonging to someone with more cash than sense. The original owner, in his twilight years, had established a foundation for conducting what appeared to be every kind of scientific research except the kind that made sense to regular folks. He'd bequeathed the villa as home base for his academic dream team. Walking through it was like stepping into someone's oversized private residence – the kind of place where you expected to find secret passages and hidden libraries. Like the TARDIS, it seemed to violate the basic laws of physics by being bigger inside than the exterior suggested.

An immaculately groomed elderly man approached with the purposeful stride of someone whose job depended on solving problems. He'd introduced himself earlier as Henry Benson,

head of security, though his operation looked like it could be defeated by a determined Girl Scout.

“When did you last lay eyes on Dr. Helsing?” I asked, crushing my unlit cigarette under heel.

“Friday evening, around nine,” Benson replied, nervousness making his voice crack like a teenager asking for a first date. “All entrances except the main door are wired with alarms round the clock. Dr. Helsing was burning the midnight oil when I left – par for the course with him.”

“Show me your greatest hits reel since Friday morning.”

We entered a cramped room housing four monitors and recording equipment that looked like it had been assembled from spare parts and good intentions. My disappointment must have shone on my face like neon.

“We’d never had trouble before,” Benson said, reading my expression with uncomfortable accuracy. “Besides, the front entrance stays locked. Everyone carries an access card.”

Right. Security through wishful thinking.

We fast-forwarded through hours of empty corridors that looked like a museum after closing time. Helsing appeared at noon Friday, walking with the confident stride of a man who owned the world. He never walked back out. Benson identified the usual parade of academics coming and going. No unfamiliar faces crossed the camera’s unblinking eye.

Then, at four Saturday morning, a figure materialized from the direction of the offices like a shadow given substance. Dark clothing, head down, moving with an awkward limp that suggested either injury or deception. He carried a backpack large enough to hide a body and a smaller bag in his right hand. His face stayed tilted toward the floor throughout his performance, but you could tell this guy understood cameras.

Benson went pale. “I don’t know this man. That backpack... it could’ve been...”

“Let’s not jump to conclusions,” I said.

The mystery man walked down the driveway and vanished into the pre-dawn darkness.

“Smart money says he parked down the road,” Benson muttered, wringing his hands like Lady Macbeth.

I printed a still frame where the intruder’s profile caught a moment of light. Dark hair, beard that looked like it might be fake, bulbous nose, glasses. Heavy build with a slight paunch. Something about his gait seemed off, beyond just the limp – like he was wearing shoes that didn’t fit or walking on ground that wasn’t quite level.

The next three hours I spent playing twenty questions with the research staff. According to his colleagues, Helsing was the second coming of Einstein crossed with Mother Teresa – brilliant, generous, beloved by all. No enemies, no unusual behavior, no dark secrets. In other words, either a saint had walked among them or everyone was lying through their teeth. In my experience, saints were in shorter supply than honest politicians.

Then I got to Amanda Barnes, and the real story started to unfold. She should’ve been my first stop, but in this business, the person with actual information is always last on the list, like some kind of cosmic joke.

She wore thick-rimmed glasses that magnified her greenish eyes until they looked like she was perpetually surprised by what the world was serving up. Under normal circumstances, I figured those eyes would hold enough good humor to light up a room. Today they were dead serious, focused on being helpful in the way that people get when death comes calling.

“Abe was having problems lately,” she said without preamble.

Direct. I liked that in a woman.

“What kind of problems?”

“The threatening kind. Over the past few months, he received several letters that made him nervous as a cat in a room full of rocking chairs. He never showed them to me, but I could tell they were eating at him. I kept pushing him to take them to the police.”

“Why would anyone want to threaten a scientist?” I asked, though I had suspicions forming like storm clouds. “Professional jealousy? Academic politics?”

She smiled, but it didn’t reach her eyes. “Detective, everyone here has talent. Or at least the complete self-assurance that they do, which amounts to the same thing in academic circles.”

“What was Helsing working on that might ruffle feathers?”

“He’d found a way to heal joints,” she said, leaning forward with the intensity of someone sharing state secrets. “A method to completely reverse arthritis. He’d just received a patent for his invention.”

“A cure for arthritis?” I whistled low. In a world where people would kill for a parking space, a breakthrough like that could start wars. “Some kind of miracle pill?”

“Better than that. No pills, no side effects, no ongoing treatments. He invented a material that gets rolled into a tight cylinder and inserted directly into the affected joint – say, the knee. Once inserted, it unfurls like the artificial lens in cataract surgery and functions as replacement cartilage.”

“Sounds simple enough,” I said, though nothing in this case was turning out simple.

“The complexity is in the material itself and the attachment method. Plus achieving compatibility with the human body – no immune rejection. It took him years to perfect.”

“When does this miracle hit the market?”

“As soon as Abe returns, he was hoping to begin clinical trials.”

I didn't have the heart to tell her that based on the security footage, her colleague's return was looking about as likely as snow in August. "Could you take a look at Dr. Helsing's office and tell me if anything's missing?"

We stood at the threshold, yellow crime scene tape creating a barrier between us and the truth. Amanda's eyes swept the office with the methodical attention of someone who knew every detail by heart.

"His laptop's gone," she said immediately. "But he always carries the networked one. That machine there is for email and internet access. His research laptop – the one that's missing – isn't connected to any network. That's where he kept all his real work. You could access his email through the networked machine, but the important stuff was on the other one."

I made a note and headed outside. No visible tracks on the gravel and asphalt – the desert heat had baked the ground harder than concrete. The K-9 unit was en route.

Rex the bloodhound hit the scent trail like he'd been shot from a cannon. The dog led us half a mile downhill from the Laboratory to a ravine that looked like the inside of a pizza oven – all red rocks baking under a sun that showed no mercy.

We found the body wedged between two boulders like discarded laundry.

The corpse's hiking pants were intact, tough enough to withstand desert scavengers and the kind of heat that could melt your fillings. That was the only thing recognizable. Two and a half days of New Mexico's August fury had mummified the flesh into something that belonged in a natural history museum. The local wildlife had held their own feast on the exposed areas – face and hands almost gone, leaving behind a horror show that would give me nightmares for weeks.

The scalp was completely hairless, colorless and tight as a drum.

After the forensic team finished their grim dance, I took a closer look. As they loaded the remains onto a stretcher, one pant leg rolled up, revealing pale, desiccated skin marked with several deep scratches that looked fresh despite the body's condition.

Helsing's office photos showed him in shorts, legs tanned dark as mahogany from all that outdoor adventure. This victim's skin was pale as a fish belly. The scratches were evenly spaced, like claw marks from something with very specific ideas about anatomy.

"Hey, Pritchett," I called out. "Any chance we can pull prints off what's left?"

"About as likely as finding ice cream in hell, but I'll give it a shot."

"Do me a favor and try the prints first thing. I've got a feeling about this one."

He nodded, understanding that in police work, feelings sometimes mattered more than facts.

Back at the Laboratory, a small crowd of researchers had gathered in the driveway like mourners at a funeral they weren't ready to attend. Someone was crying – soft, broken sobs that cut through the desert air like a blade. Amanda's face was composed, but tears tracked down her cheeks in silver lines.

I kept my question silent. She nodded anyway.

"Are you certain?"

"Those are his clothes," she said simply.

One last detail to nail down. "Do you know if Helsing ever had his fingerprints taken?" I asked Benson.

"Standard security procedure for everyone. We keep the records on file."

Perfect.

Pritchett called two hours later while I was nursing bad coffee and worse thoughts back at the station.

“Got partials from two fingertips,” he said. “Quality’s poor, but workable. Ran them through every database we’ve got access to – IAFIS, state records, military, the works.”

“And?”

“Nothing. Zero. Zilch. Either this guy never existed in any official capacity, or someone’s gone to considerable trouble to erase him from the records.”

The body belonged to a ghost. In the Land of Enchantment, even the dead kept secrets.

Back at the station, I spent the rest of the day arranging facts like puzzle pieces that didn’t want to fit together. The forensics reports wouldn’t be ready until tomorrow, but I already knew they weren’t going to solve this case. Too many pieces were missing, and the ones I had painted a picture that made about as much sense as a chocolate teapot.

Instead of heading home to my empty apartment and a TV dinner, I found myself driving back to the Laboratory. Sometimes a case spoke to you in whispers, and you had to listen when nobody else was around to interfere.

Benson was securing the building for the night, his routine as precise as a Swiss watch. He let me in, showed me the alarm system that probably couldn’t stop a determined teenager, and departed for his own evening of well-deserved rest.

The corridors felt different after hours – longer, more mysterious, filled with the kind of shadows that made you check corners twice. I wandered the halls like a ghost myself, trying to feel what the killer had felt, think what he’d thought.

In the lobby, a wall displayed photographs of all the resident scientists, each face radiating the confidence that came with advanced degrees and government grants. Helsing’s portrait was larger than the others, positioned prominently in the center. Kind hazel eyes surrounded by squint

lines earned through years of desert sun, determination etched in the set of his jaw, humor playing at the corners of his mouth.

An unearthly shriek shattered the silence like a fire alarm having a nervous breakdown. I spun toward the sound, hand instinctively moving toward my service weapon.

The ginger tom was on his feet, transformed into something out of a horror movie. Every hair on his substantial frame stood at attention, ears flattened against his skull, back arched like a bridge to nowhere. He was yowling with the intensity of an air raid siren, eyes fixed on something behind me.

I understood the cat's warning a split second before I felt the breath on my neck. Training kicked in, and I dropped toward the floor as something whistled through the air where my head had been occupying space a heartbeat earlier. The sound told me the weapon was heavy, fast, and wielded by someone who knew how to use it.

I rolled hard to the right, came up in a crouch, and faced my attacker. Black clothing head to toe, ski mask covering his features, tactical baton in his left hand. The way he held it told me he was military trained and wouldn't give me time to clear my weapon from its holster.

He advanced with the confidence of a predator, balanced on the balls of his feet, weapon ready to cave in my skull. Instead of backing away, I dropped low and slid across the polished wooden floor like a baseball player stealing home plate. My right foot caught him just below the kneecap with all the force I could generate.

The crack echoed through the lobby like a gunshot. Physics is a beautiful thing when it works in your favor – his knee joint decided to bend in a direction human anatomy never intended. He went down hard, screaming like a banshee with its tail caught in a door.

I was on my feet and calling for backup while he writhed on the floor, clutching his ruined knee. The sound he was making would have made a wounded animal feel sorry for him.

“That’s going to need surgery,” I observed, lighting a cigarette while we waited for the cavalry. “Assuming you live long enough to see a doctor.”

He had no identification and clamped up tighter than a Cayman Island bank once the ambulance crew shot him full of enough morphine to stop the screaming. Could be shock, could be professional discipline. Either way, he was taking a ride to the hospital with an escort who carried handcuffs and a badge.

Two attempts on the Laboratory in as many days suggested whoever was running this operation had a serious hard-on for something inside these walls. Maybe the first intruder hadn’t found what he was looking for in Helsing’s office. Maybe the body in the desert belonged to someone else entirely, and this was round two of a very dangerous game.

I looked around for the cat, but he’d vanished into the night like smoke. Smart animal. In the desert, even the predators knew when to disappear.

Sleep came just in time for the alarm clock to ruin it. My reflection in the bathroom mirror looked like something that should be in the morgue instead of working cases. A shower and shave helped marginally. Maybe enough coffee to float a battleship would finish the job.

I was halfway to the Laboratory when Pritchett’s call came through my radio like a lightning bolt.

“Your friend from last night? Different set of prints, same story. Unknown to every database in the known universe. And he’s still not talking – hasn’t said a word since the morphine wore off.”

Two ghosts in two days. Either I'd stumbled into the X-Files, or someone was running a very sophisticated operation with very professional help.

The parking lot at the Laboratory looked like a federal invasion. Black SUVs arranged in perfect formation, windows tinted dark enough to hide state secrets. I'd taken maybe five steps from my cruiser when a squad of matching suits emerged from behind the vehicles like they'd been manufactured in the same factory.

The lead suit was tall, thin, and radiated the kind of authority that came with a government paycheck and no sense of humor. Without bothering with introductions, he stepped into my personal space.

"Detective Martinez. Please call your lieutenant." His voice had all the warmth of a tax audit.

The urge to demonstrate my new knee-breaking technique was almost overwhelming, but these boys traveled in packs and probably carried weapons that would make my service revolver look like a cap gun. I pulled out my phone and dialed.

Lieutenant Santos was not having a good morning. I could hear him grinding his teeth from three miles away.

"Case is federal jurisdiction now, Martinez. National security implications. Turn over everything – notes, evidence, the works. And take a couple days off while they sort this mess out."

The line went dead. The federal boys and girls didn't even pretend to be interested in a debrief. They'd probably been monitoring the investigation from the beginning, waiting for the right moment to swoop in and make everything disappear into a classified file cabinet.

I drove away feeling oddly relieved instead of frustrated. Federal cases were like quicksand – the more you struggled, the deeper you sank. Better to let them handle whatever alphabet soup agency business this had turned into.

Time for breakfast and some serious thinking.

I found a shaded bench in the Plaza and settled in with coffee strong enough to wake the dead and a breakfast burrito that could feed a small family. The morning crowds were starting to build – tourists in search of authentic Southwestern culture, locals trying to get through another day in paradise.

The case was officially out of my hands, but that didn't stop my mind from worrying the details like a dog with a favorite bone. Two professional operators, both unknown to law enforcement, both interested in something inside the Laboratory. A missing scientist with a breakthrough invention worth millions, maybe billions. A body in the desert that might or might not belong to the right person.

"Beautiful morning," said a voice behind me.

I turned to find a slight man with longish sandy hair and a mustache that belonged in a barbershop quartet – waxed, twisted, and complicated enough to require engineering blueprints. He gestured toward the empty half of the bench.

"Mind if I share? Just finished a walkabout and I'm waiting for the bus to Arizona."

Despite the Australian terminology, his accent was pure American Midwest – Iowa or Nebraska, somewhere flat and honest.

"Hiking?" I asked, making conversation while I studied him. Something about the guy seemed familiar, but I couldn't place it.

“Yeah, spent some time in the backcountry. Getting back to nature, clearing the head. You know how it is.” He unloaded a small backpack and what looked like a pet carrier. “Hell of a thing about that murder in the papers. Who kills a scientist? What’s your take on it?”

Why not? The feds had the case now, and talking to civilians was like thinking out loud – sometimes it helped you see angles you’d missed.

“Victim had something someone wanted badly enough to kill for,” I said. “Smart guy, invented a cure for arthritis.”

“Really?” His eyes lit up with genuine interest. “Well, that explains everything. Think about the pharmaceutical companies, the surgical equipment manufacturers, all the people making money off arthritis sufferers. An invention like that could put a lot of powerful people out of business.”

The logic was sound. Cleaner than anything I’d come up with.

“But the guy just got a patent,” I pointed out. “Nobody could steal it legally.”

“Who said anything about legal?” The stranger’s smile was knowing. “Maybe they wanted to buy the patent so they could bury it. Keep making money off people’s pain for another few decades. You said he was a good guy? Maybe he wouldn’t sell. Maybe he planned to make the cure available to everyone.”

That would explain the threatening letters Amanda had mentioned. It would also explain why professional operators were involved – the kind of money we were talking about could buy armies.

“You said he was smart,” my bench companion continued. “Maybe he saw trouble coming and got ready for it. You certain that body belongs to him?”

Bingo. The pale skin, the wrong fingerprints, the scratches that looked like they'd been made post-mortem to suggest animal predation. Someone had gone to considerable trouble to create a convincing corpse.

"Hard to say for sure," I admitted. "Desert heat and wildlife don't leave much to work with."

"Hot day brewing," he observed, glancing at the cloudless sky.

"Yeah, but it's dry heat."

"Really dry," he agreed.

I noticed a small problem with his face and helpfully rubbed my finger across my upper lip.

He smiled and pressed a fingertip to one corner of his elaborate mustache, where the adhesive wasn't holding as well as it should.

"Watch the news tomorrow," he said, standing and shouldering his pack. "Well, time to catch that bus. Nice talking to you, Detective."

"Same here."

We shook hands – his grip was firm, callused, the hands of someone who worked with tools and wasn't afraid of getting dirty. As he walked away, I noticed his pet carrier had shifted slightly in the morning sun. For just a moment, I could have sworn I saw familiar green eyes watching me from the shadows inside.

But that was probably just my imagination.

I did watch the news the next morning. Every channel was running the same story: "ARTHRITIS CURE RELEASED TO PUBLIC" and "BREAKTHROUGH TREATMENT AVAILABLE TO ALL" scrolled across screens in letters big enough to read from orbit.

According to the reports, Dr. Abraham Helsing had made his revolutionary arthritis treatment available through open-source medical research, bypassing pharmaceutical companies and making the cure freely available to any doctor or medical facility worldwide. The patent had been released into the public domain with detailed manufacturing specifications.

Interviews with medical professionals called it the most significant breakthrough in joint therapy since the development of modern prosthetics. Stock prices for arthritis drug manufacturers were in free fall.

I still had a few years before arthritis became my problem, but it was good to know I wouldn't have to look forward to it.

And somewhere in Arizona, a man with a complicated mustache and his green-eyed traveling companion were probably reading the same headlines, smiling at a job well done.

In the desert, sometimes the good guys actually win.

Even if they have to die first to make it happen.